Prompt Anatomy Cheat Sheet: Role, Task, Context, Format, and Constraints

Introduction

Every prompt that actually works is built from the same five parts, whether you can see them or not. This reading breaks a prompt down into those parts — role, task, context, format, and constraints — so you have a repeatable checklist instead of guessing at wording each time. Keep this one bookmarked; you'll use it every time you write a prompt from here on.

The five parts of a prompt



Not every prompt needs all five explicitly — a quick one-off question might skip role and format entirely. But when a prompt isn't giving you what you want, the fix is almost always: which of these five did I leave out or leave vague?

Seeing it in a real prompt

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You are a technical writer for a beginner audience.          Role
Rewrite the paragraph below so a first-year student          Task
can follow it without a glossary.
Paragraph: "Attention mechanisms compute a weighted sum..."  Context
Return the result as a single paragraph, no headers.         Format
Keep it under 80 words and avoid the word "mechanism."       Constraints
```

Notice the order isn't rigid — role often comes first to set tone, but context can lead if the task depends heavily on it. What matters is that all five show up somewhere, clearly.

Why each part earns its place

Part	What happens if you skip it
Role	Model defaults to a generic, unfocused voice
Task	Model guesses at intent — often the wrong guess
Context	Output is generic, not grounded in your specifics
Format	You get prose when you needed a table (or vice versa)
Constraints	Output runs long, uses banned terms, or ignores limits

A quick self-check before you send a prompt

- [ ] Have I told the model who to be?
- [ ] Is the task specific, unambiguous, actionable?
- [ ] Did I include everything the model needs to know — and nothing it doesn't?
- [ ] Did I specify the output shape, not just the content?
- [ ] Are my limits (length, tone, exclusions) stated explicitly, not implied?

Summary

